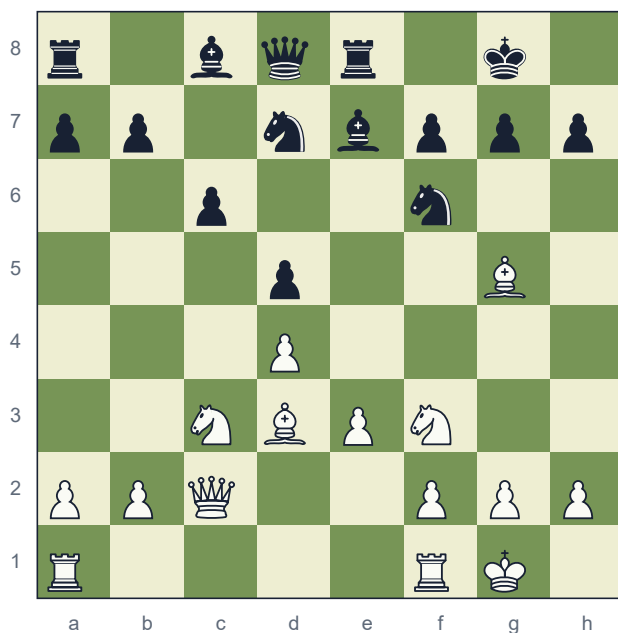


# Queen's Gambit Declined: the Exchange

1.d4 d5 2.c4 e6 3.Nf3 Nf6 4.Nc3

## YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Exchange on d5 once Black has committed to ...e6 and ...Nf6. Develop with Bg5, e3 and Bd3, castle, and only then decide how to use the queenside majority imbalance.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

## THE PAWN STRUCTURE

The Carlsbad structure: White's c-pawn and Black's original d-pawn have been exchanged. Black's e-pawn stands on d5, supported by a c-pawn. White often attacks c6 with b4-b5; Black seeks kingside activity or the freeing ...c5.

## WHAT BLACK WANTS

Black wants ...Ne4, piece exchanges that reduce pressure, or ...c5 before you organize a minority attack. Development can matter more than a permanent pawn weakness.

## THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. This repertoire already puts the king knight on f3. Do not copy a Ne2-f3-e4 scheme as though that knight were still on g1.
2. A minority attack is a prepared plan, not an instruction to play b4 before castling.
3. If Black achieves ...c5 safely, recalculate the structure: an isolated d-pawn or a symmetrical position may replace the Carlsbad.

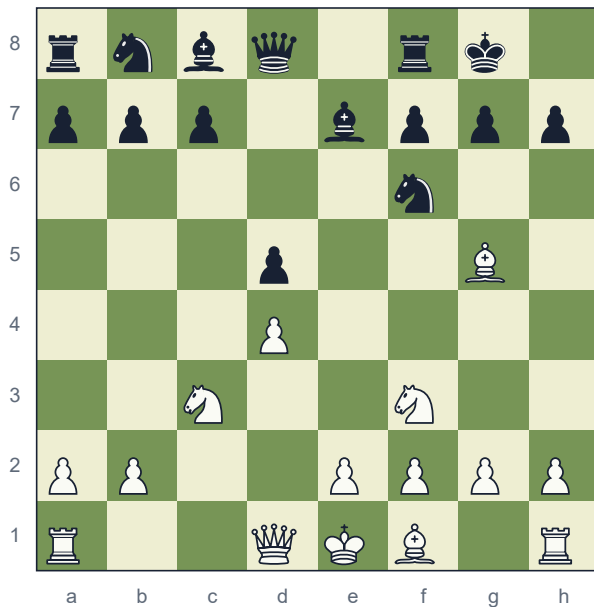
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

# 01 The normal Carlsbad setup

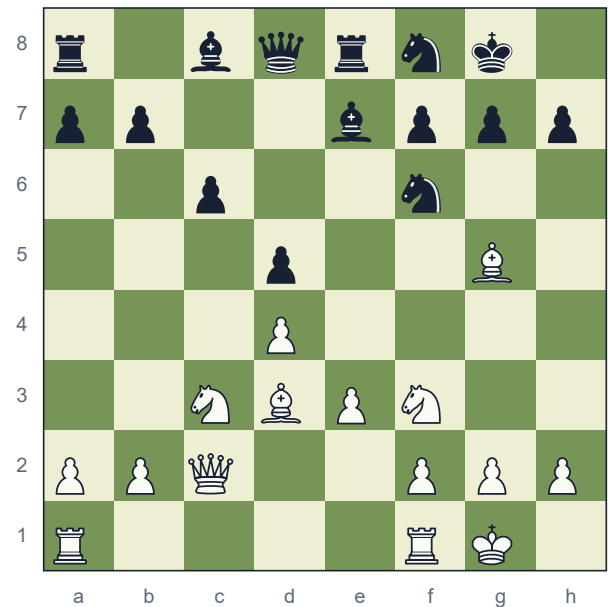
## STUDY LINE 02-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Be7 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 O-O 7. e3 c6 8. Bd3 Nbd7 9. O-O Re8 10. Qc2 Nf8

Selected anchor ends with 10. Qc2. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

## WHY THESE MOVES

cx d5 fixes a structure you can study repeatedly. Bg5 develops outside the e3 pawn chain; Bd3 points at h7 while supporting later central play.

## YOUR NEXT PLAN

Complete development with a rook on b1 or c1 according to Black's setup. Prepare b4-b5, and meet a kingside initiative with exchanges or a central break.

## WATCH FOR

The bishop sacrifice Bxh7+ is not justified merely because your bishop points at h7. Check the king's escape squares and whether Ng5 is effective.

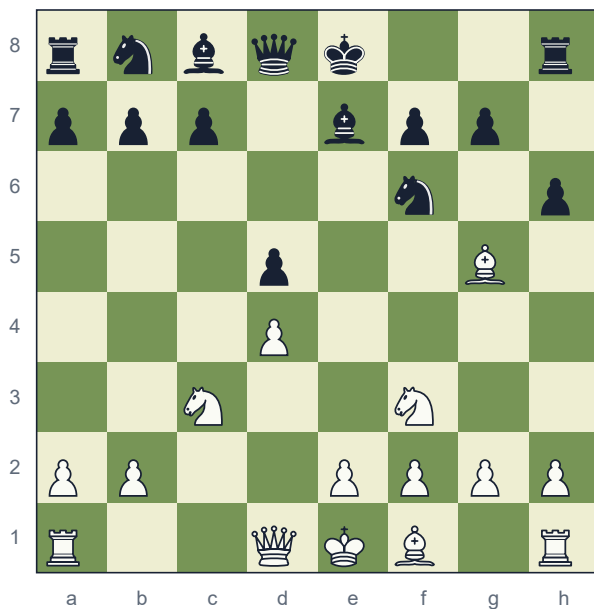
**REMEMBER** Exchange, develop, castle, then choose the pawn break.

## 02 Black exchanges the g5 bishop

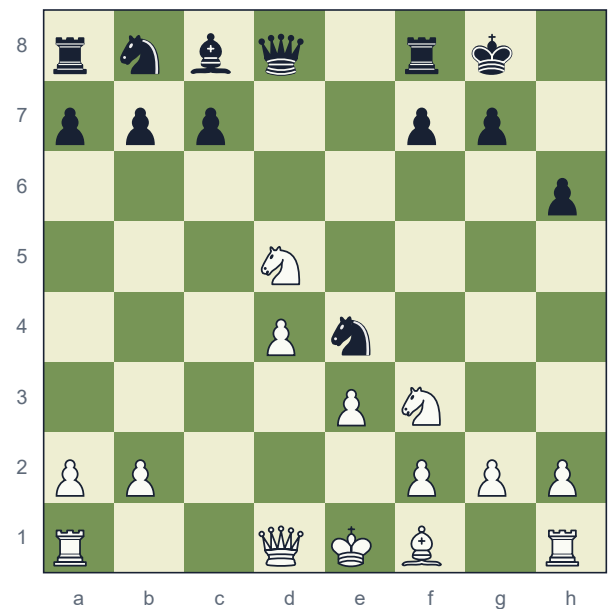
### STUDY LINE 02-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Be7 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 O-O 8. e3 Ne4 9. Bxe7 Qxe7 10. Nxd5 Qd8

Selected anchor ends with 10. Nxd5. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

### WHY THESE MOVES

Bh4 keeps the pin available; when the knight reaches e4, exchanging on e7 simplifies the pressure on your bishop without abandoning development.

### YOUR NEXT PLAN

In this exact position, Nxd5 takes a pawn that Black no longer adequately protects. Continue development while meeting any queen or knight activity.

### WATCH FOR

Do not copy Nxd5 into a position where Black has already played ...c6. That extra pawn would control d5.

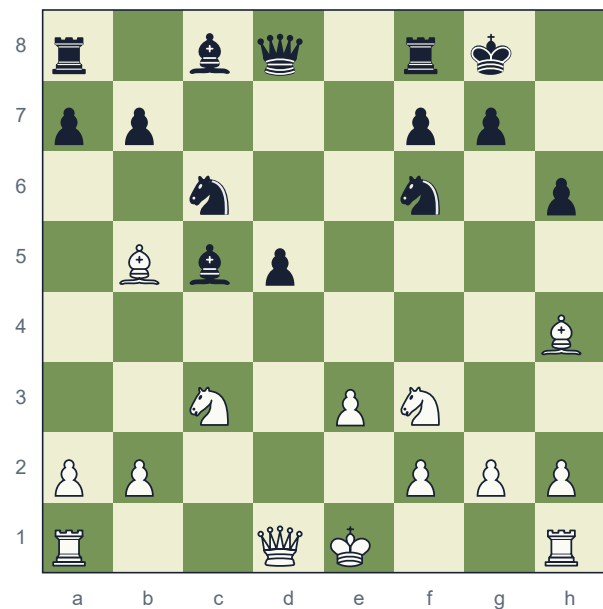
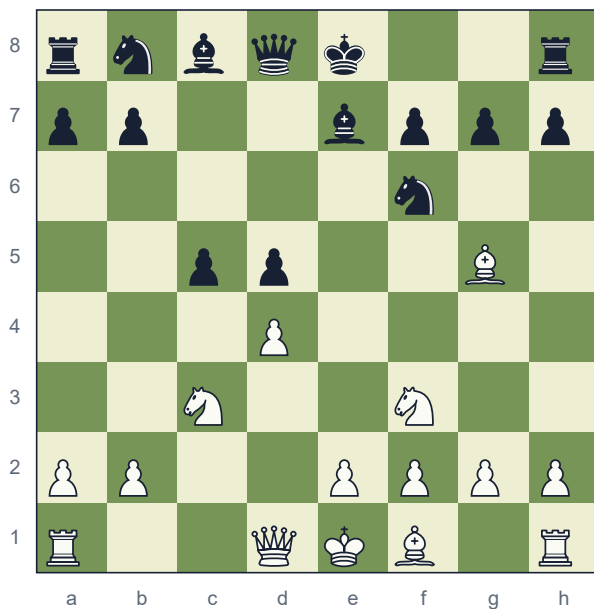
**REMEMBER** An exact move-order detail can matter more than a familiar plan.

## 03 Early ...c5 changes the structure

### STUDY LINE 02-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Be7 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 c5 7. e3 Nc6 8. dxc5 O-O 9. Bb5 h6 10. Bh4 Bxc5

Selected anchor ends with 7... Nc6. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



### WHY THESE MOVES

Black challenges d4 immediately. Keep developing while monitoring the tension rather than forcing a minority-attack script onto the position.

### YOUR NEXT PLAN

After exchanges on c5 or d4, identify whose d-pawn is isolated. Blockade an enemy isolated pawn with pieces; use activity if the isolated pawn is yours.

### WATCH FOR

A rook on b1 can be pointless when the main battle has moved to the central files.

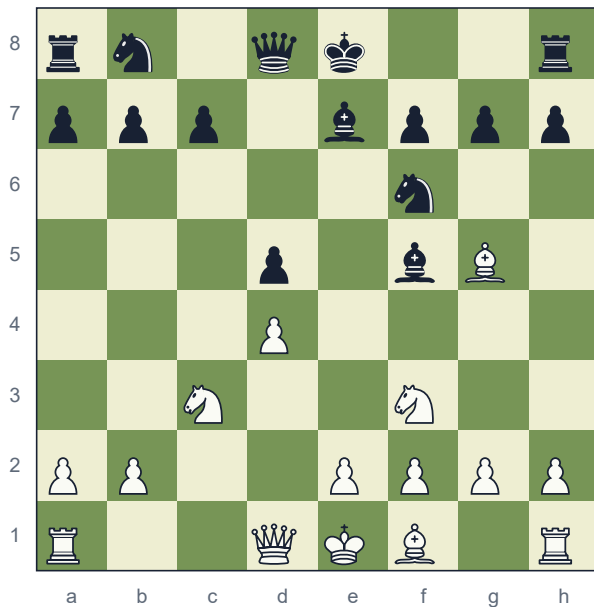
**REMEMBER** Name the new structure before selecting a plan.

## 04 The bishop comes to f5 too soon

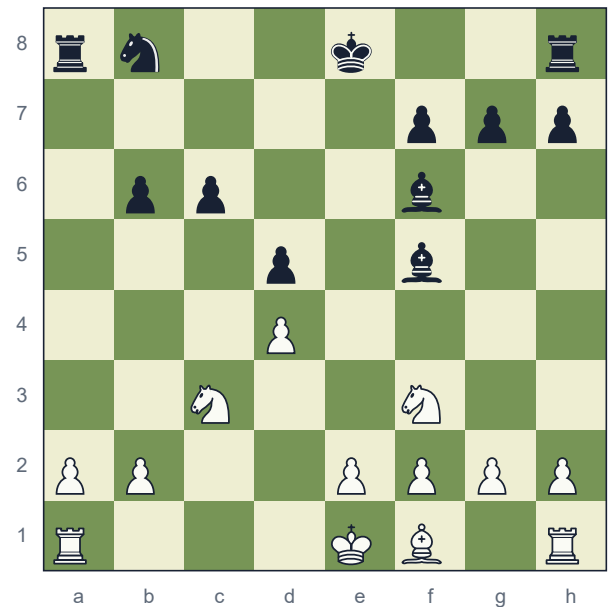
### STUDY LINE 02-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Be7 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 Bf5 7. Bxf6 Bxf6 8. Qb3 c6 9. Qxb7 Qb6 10. Qxb6 axb6

Selected anchor ends with 7. Bxf6. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 6 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

### WHY THESE MOVES

Exchanging the f6 knight removes a defender of d5. This concrete detail makes automatic e3 less ambitious in this exact position.

### YOUR NEXT PLAN

Inspect d5 and b7 after Black recaptures. Queen pressure on the queenside may force concessions before you complete normal development.

### WATCH FOR

This tactic depends on Black not yet having played ...c6 or castled. Check the exact position before repeating it.

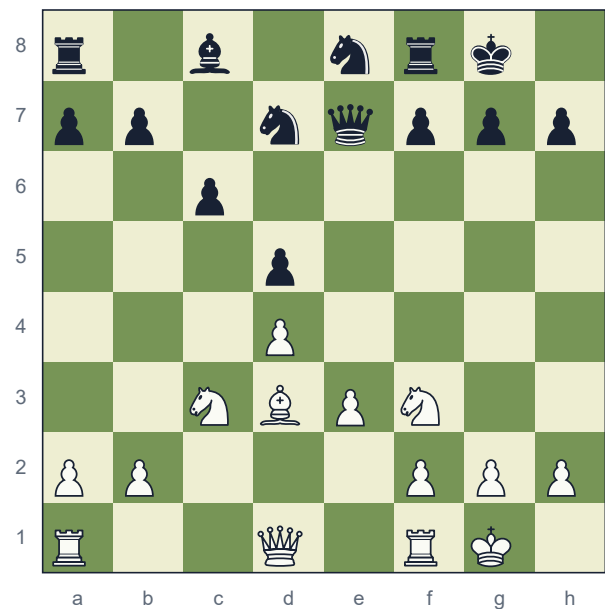
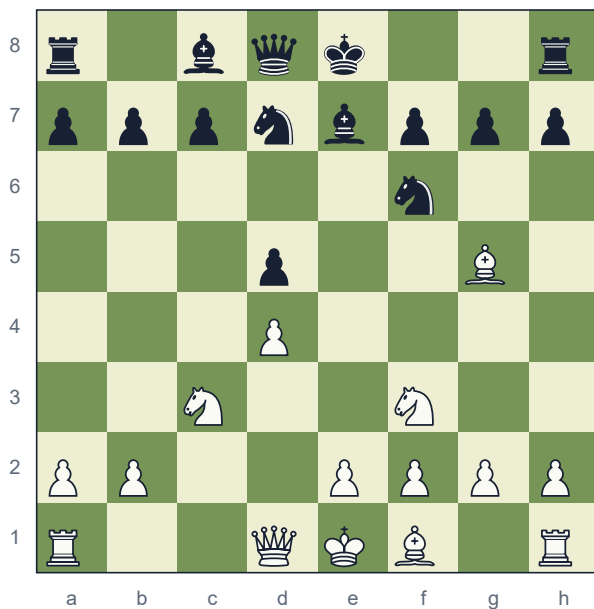
**REMEMBER** Remove a defender when the central target is real.

## 05 Black develops ...Nbd7 before ...Be7

### STUDY LINE 02-05

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Nbd7 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 Be7 7. e3 O-O 8. Bd3 c6 9. O-O Ne8 10. Bxe7 Qxe7

Selected anchor ends with 9. O-O. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



### WHY THESE MOVES

This move order reaches the same familiar structure. Recognizing the transposition saves unnecessary memorization.

### YOUR NEXT PLAN

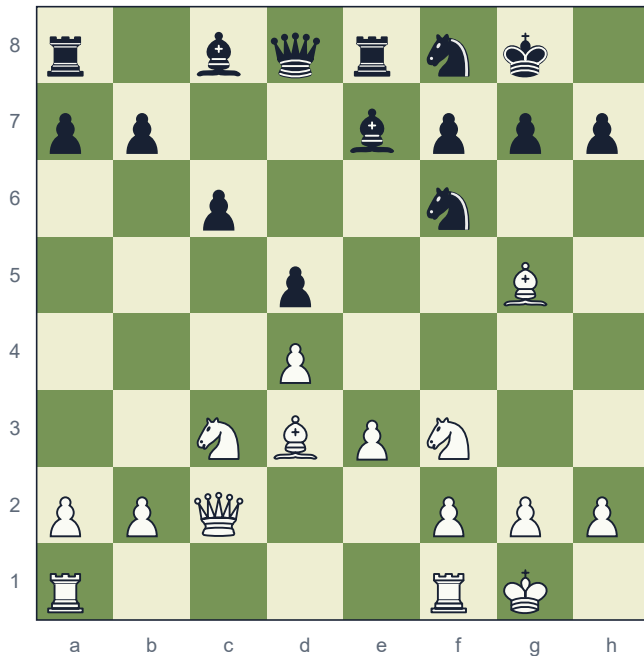
Qc2, Rab1 and b4 are possible preparations. Keep an eye on ...Ne4 and ...Re8 before committing.

### WATCH FOR

Transpositions depend on the exact piece placement and whose turn it is. Similar pawn structures alone do not prove two positions are identical.

**REMEMBER** Recognize the setup, verify the move order.

# Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

## 1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

The Carlsbad structure: White's c-pawn and Black's original d-pawn have been exchanged. Black's e-pawn stands on d5, supported by a c-pawn. White often attacks c6 with b4-b5; Black seeks kingside activity or the freeing ...c5.

## 2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

Black wants ...Ne4, piece exchanges that reduce pressure, or ...c5 before you organize a minority attack. Development can matter more than a permanent pawn weakness.

## 3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Complete development with a rook on b1 or c1 according to Black's setup. Prepare b4-b5, and meet a kingside initiative with exchanges or a central break.

## RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

## DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

## SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.